

THE CLAIM

# ChatGPT sends you traffic. It also sends most of it to Google

Outbound referrals grew 206% in a year, and more than a fifth of them land on Google rather than on the publisher being cited.

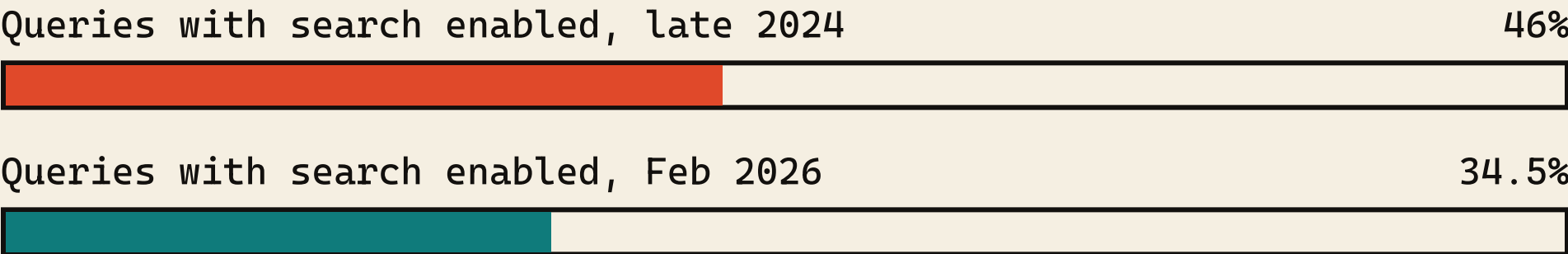
|                                       |       |
|---------------------------------------|-------|
| REFERRAL GROWTH, JAN 2025 TO JAN 2026 | +206% |
| SHARE OF REFERRALS GOING TO GOOGLE    | 21.6% |
| QUERIES THAT EVEN TRIGGER SEARCH      | 34.5% |

Semrush, 17-month ChatGPT clickstream study, October 2024 to February 2026.

02 / WHY IT MATTERS

Only **34.5%** of questions trigger a search at all.

When search is off, the model answers from what it already read. Being absent from that memory costs you silently.



Semrush, ChatGPT clickstream study, October 2024 to February 2026. Search usage fell as model recall improved.

03 / THE PROOF

+206%

growth in outbound referral traffic from ChatGPT between January 2025 and January 2026.

|                              |           |
|------------------------------|-----------|
| REFERRAL GROWTH YEAR ON YEAR | +206%     |
| STUDY WINDOW                 | 17 months |
| SEARCH-ENABLED QUERY SHARE   | 34.5%     |
| REFERRALS LANDING ON GOOGLE  | 21.6%     |

Semrush, 17-month ChatGPT clickstream study, October 2024 to February 2026.

04 / HOW A REFERRAL IS BORN

A citation needs the model to look something up

STEP 01

The query needs a fact the model cannot recall

STEP 02

Search runs and returns a short set of sources

STEP 03

The answer cites one and links out

SEARCH ENABLED

34.5% of queries

EVERYTHING ELSE

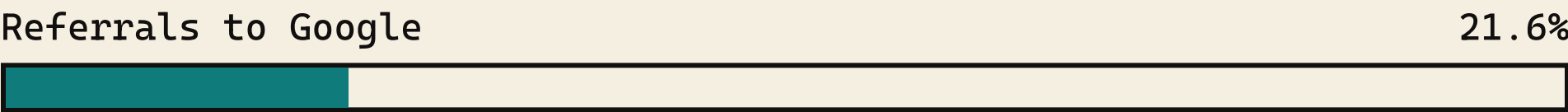
answered from memory

Semrush clickstream study. With search off, the citation comes from material the model already indexed or remembered.

# A fifth of the traffic you win goes straight to Google

21.6%

Share of ChatGPT outbound referrals landing on Google rather than on the cited publisher.



## CREATOR VS COMPANY PAGE CITATIONS, CHATGPT 59% creators

Semrush, clickstream study; Semrush, 89,000 cited LinkedIn URLs, March 2026.

## 06 / WHAT TO DO



# Own the memory, not just the **click**

## 01 Publish the fact you want recalled

When search is off the model answers from memory. A clear, dated, specific statement is what gets remembered.

## 02 Keep an asset that forces a live lookup

A calculator, a price or an updated list makes the model search, and search is where citations are created.

## 03 Report AI referrals separately from organic

Assistant traffic arrives without a keyword. If it is not segmented it looks like direct traffic and vanishes from your reporting.

Sources: Semrush, ChatGPT clickstream study, 2026; Semrush, 89,000 cited URLs, March 2026.

## THE TAKEAWAY

# Ask ChatGPT about your topic. Then ask whether it mentions you

That answer is your new rankings page. Check it the way you used to check position one.

## STEP ONE

run the question your buyer would type

## STEP TWO

list the sources it names

## FOLLOW

for the fixes that move it

Source: Semrush, ChatGPT clickstream study, 2026.